



Become the audience

We tell you why it's high time you installed HTPC software, sat back and truly relished your home theatre setup..

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LCD and plasma TVs sales have seen a phenomenal increase recently, and this should continue with falling prices. Most users don't have a clue about high definition and the ones who do cannot access it. HD broadcasts today are almost non-existent in India and the distribution of Blu-ray discs is still in its infancy. In the past issues of *Digit*, we've shown you how to build an HTPC and why it's so useful.

Just setting up a compact PC and running an OS doesn't make an HTPC and doesn't bring out the fun either. What helps is installing HTPC software that makes the operation of the PC completely hassle-free and tunes everything to the very bare basics. A Windows Media Center Remote or a wireless keyboard is all that you need. There is no shortage of good HTPC front-end programs and they're available for every operating system you can imagine. Of the available options, we like XBMC this is a widely talked about program, and for good reason.

XBMC is free, open-source, and can be downloaded from www.xbmc.org. The last stable release was version 8.10 and a new alpha release 9.04 Alpha has just been produced. XBMC is also available for the Xbox, Apple TV and also a LiveCD for the PC.

We like the idea of HTPC systems and software for several reasons. They let you view your TV from a distance and operate all the media functions using a single input device. Your entire database of media can be easily accessed from either a server on the network, a NAS, a camera or even directly streamed over the internet. While the same can be done using any operating system, software such as XBMC make it so much simpler and do it in a very interactive and colourful manner. XBMC can handle most file formats. We're going to look through some of XBMC's features and help you set things up. We'll also briefly look through some of the less popular HTPC front-ends.

The system requirements for XBMC aren't too high either, but a decent graphics solution is always recommended for the smooth transition effects and interface animations. Installation of XBMC is quick and easy.

The entire program is menu driven and requires minimal input on your part. Most of the features are automated once you set it up. In fact, it's so simple that you can use a keyboard to access all functions without having to ever use the mouse. You can also purchase a cheap media centre remote control and have it configured to keys you would use on your keyboard. Another way to control the HTPC is through a gaming controller such as the Xbox360 controller.

To further simplify it, we suggest setting up Windows in a manner that it automatically starts XBMC on bootup. To do this, we assume that there is a single user setup on Windows. This will ensure that the account automatically logs on if there's no password set. Click on the Startup folder in the Start menu. Right-click on it and click Explore. Create a shortcut in it which points to XBMC's executable. Now every time Windows boots, XBMC will start up so you don't have to manually start XBMC from the Start menu.

Movie handling on XBMC

Movies are mainly the reason people setup an HTPC. Although standard DVD and DivX players can run most formats, there's one

thing they can't do well — play HD videos. For this, even a low-end dual core processor with a decent amount of memory can do the job perfectly. Obviously a faster processor and a good graphics solution will go a long way and you won't have to upgrade the HTPC any time soon.

To watch movies on XBMC, one needs to go to the Movies menu. Use the arrow keys to move up and down the menus and press [Enter] when you reach the menu. You can also use the mouse to click on the menus and features.

When you do this for the first time, your movies and video collection need to be imported. You can set multiple locations as the source for the videos and this includes network connections. This is useful when you have two or more PCs at home. You can share a folder on another PC and access the share over the network. To do this, go to Movies > Add Video Source. Click on Browse and choose the paths. Click OK when done. You can set additional sources in this same manner by clicking on Add and then Browse.

Setting content type for media

To set the folder you've added to a content type, click on Set Content. Click the up/down arrows and set the type of media. Choose between Movies, TV Shows and Music Videos. Enable the button for Run Automated Scan. This will enable XBMC to query the video information and get the appropriate information on the movie. For example, it'll show you a short brief of the movie, it's overall rating, fan-art, etc. We've chosen IMDb.com, but you can choose from any of the sites listed.

Getting XBMC to download covers

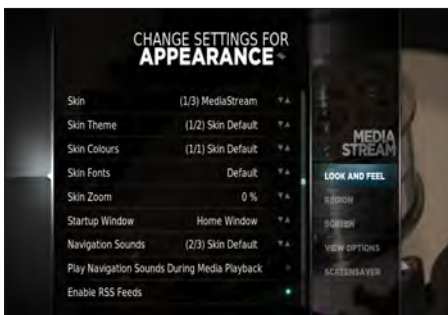
Having movie names as text alongside a default image name is boring. Similar to downloading of movie details, XBMC can also download movie covers. Although this might seem silly, it's a great combination when used with a more advanced theme or script for XBMC. For a trial, set the MediaStream theme for XBMC through the Settings > Appearance menu. We prefer the MediaStream theme. Once the theme is set, go back to the Settings menu. Remember that the skin that you choose changes the functionality of the software a bit and also the menu names.

All the media that is added to XBMC can have the album covers downloaded for you. Typically on a PC, you need to manually set folders to be scanned for the album and some software even requires you to choose an album cover. Go to XBMC Settings > Music > Library. Here, choose the radio buttons for album cover and information to be downloaded while adding to the library. XBMC will scan each of the albums added automatically and download the covers for you. You can also do this for movies and TV shows.

Using the XBMC interface (on MediaStream)

The XBMC interface looks good, but isn't as exciting or polished as some of the interfaces we see on media players and gaming consoles. MediaStream as a theme is much closer to that and to some, even better than those.

All the menus can be accessed by pressing the up and down keys and pressing [Enter] to access them. The submenus can usually be accessed by pressing the left and right keys. The [Tab] and [Esc] keys



Changing XBMC themes changes the look and some of the menus and features